

Bao Rescue

A photo-first troubleshooting guide for steamed buns: compare the symptom, check likely causes, then change one variable.

PHOTO-FIRST GUIDE

Fast visual diagnosis

Not another long recipe PDF. Find the photo that looks closest to your batch and move straight to the most useful checks.

Inside

- 6 symptom pages with realistic reference photos
- Normal-vs-failure comparison
- Short diagnosis notes
- 30-second flow + next-batch worksheet

RULE

How to use

- Match the visual symptom
- Check the top cause first
- Change only one major variable



Quick Symptom Atlas

Start here. Find the closest visual match before reading the detailed page.



Wrinkled / elephant skin

Shrunk, puckered surface.



Collapsed

Flattened or sunken shape.



Dense / not fluffy

Tight, heavy interior crumb.



Wet / pitted

Drops, dimples, soggy spots.



Barely rose

Small, tight, limited expansion.



Cracked / split

Top tears during steaming.

Wrinkled / Elephant Skin

Use the photo first. Then check the highest-probability causes before changing multiple variables.

WRINKLED



NORMAL REFERENCE

What it looks like

The skin looks puckered, crepey or slightly shrunken rather than smooth and full.

PRIORITY

Check first

- Check proofing state first; weak structure can wrinkle after steaming.
- Also check the post-steam lid transition; rapid cooling can worsen shrinkage.
- If the shaped skin dried during proofing, roughness can become more obvious.

ACTION

Next batch: change one thing

- Keep the formula unchanged and adjust only proofing readiness or time.
- If proofing looked right, test a gentler lid-opening transition.
- Keep shaped buns covered so the outer skin stays supple.

Collapsed / Overproofed

Use the photo first. Then check the highest-probability causes before changing multiple variables.

COLLAPSED



NORMAL REFERENCE

What it looks like

The buns flatten, sink, or lose volume. They may look puffy before steaming but cannot hold structure.

PRIORITY

Check first

- Overproofing is a strong first candidate.
- Check whether later batches waited much longer before steaming.
- A sudden post-steam temperature change can amplify collapse in a weak bun.

ACTION

Next batch: change one thing

- Shorten final proof or keep later batches cooler while waiting.
- Steam one small test batch earlier and compare.
- If shape improves, keep the shorter proof as the next baseline.

Dense / Not Fluffy

Use the photo first. Then check the highest-probability causes before changing multiple variables.

DENSE



NORMAL REFERENCE

What it looks like

The outside can look acceptable while the inside stays compact, tight, moist or heavy instead of airy.

PRIORITY

Check first

- First ask whether the dough actually rose before steaming.
- If it rose, check final proof, flour choice, hydration and dough structure.
- Do not assume dense always means dead yeast.

ACTION

Next batch: change one thing

- Record the exact flour and hydration used.
- Choose one test: slightly longer proof, yeast verification, or hydration correction.
- Compare crumb after that single change.

Wet / Pitted Surface

Use the photo first. Then check the highest-probability causes before changing multiple variables.

CONDENSATION



NORMAL REFERENCE

What it looks like

The surface has shiny wet spots, droplets, dimples or soggy patches instead of an even steamed finish.

PRIORITY

Check first

- Check for lid condensation dripping directly onto buns.
- Metal steamer setups can concentrate droplets differently from bamboo.
- Visible droplets make condensation a high-priority branch.

ACTION

Next batch: change one thing

- Control direct drips first and keep other variables the same.
- Use a lid/cloth setup that moves condensation away from the buns.
- If the surface becomes cleaner, you isolated a major cause.

Barely Rose / Underproofed

Use the photo first. Then check the highest-probability causes before changing multiple variables.

UNDERPROOFED



NORMAL REFERENCE

What it looks like

The buns remain smaller, tighter and more compact. The dough never becomes light and puffy enough before steaming.

PRIORITY

Check first

- Check yeast freshness and the method appropriate to that yeast type.
- Check room and ingredient temperature; cool dough moves more slowly.
- Judge dough state, not the clock alone.

ACTION

Next batch: change one thing

- Give the dough a warmer, stable proof environment if needed.
- Let one sample proof a little longer and compare volume and lightness.
- Use visual and touch cues to decide when to steam.

Cracked / Split Top

Use the photo first. Then check the highest-probability causes before changing multiple variables.

CRACKED



NORMAL REFERENCE

What it looks like

The outer skin tears instead of stretching smoothly as the bun expands under steam.

PRIORITY

Check first

- Underproofing is a common branch: expansion continues aggressively during steaming.
- A dry or overly tight surface can crack more easily.
- Shaping tension and uneven structure can also contribute.

ACTION

Next batch: change one thing

- Proof a little further and compare whether the skin stretches more smoothly.
- Keep shaped buns covered during proofing.
- Keep shaping consistent and avoid excessive outer tension.

30-Second Diagnosis Flow

Use this if you are not sure which symptom page to start with.

- | | | |
|----------|--|----------------|
| 1 | Visible droplets / soggy pits?
YES -> Wet / Pitted | NO -> continue |
| 2 | Stayed small and tight?
YES -> Underproofed | NO -> continue |
| 3 | Flattened or sank?
YES -> Collapsed | NO -> continue |
| 4 | Wrinkled / crepey skin?
YES -> Wrinkled | NO -> continue |
| 5 | Heavy tight interior?
YES -> Dense | NO -> continue |
| 6 | Top split open?
YES -> Cracked | NO -> continue |

Next Batch Worksheet

A failed batch becomes useful only when the next test is clear.

Recipe / source

Flour used

Yeast type / freshness

Room temperature

First proof observations

Final proof observations

Steamer setup

Visible symptom

Main hypothesis

ONE variable to change next batch